

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, March 24, 2021, in the Council Chambers of City Hall and via Zoom.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 6:30 p.m.

Mayor Lovett read the following statement: *This meeting is being conducted in accordance with the provisions of the Governor's Executive Order no. 2020-04 and the emergency meeting provisions of RSA 91-A to permit participation of board members by electronic means. Under the conditions of the current COVID-19 pandemic and the protocols established by the Centers for Disease Control (CDC), it is not reasonably practical for a quorum of this board's members to attend this meeting in person.*

To join the webinar:

<https://us02web.zoom.us/j/81529457408?pwd=dmpEQ1BRNXNibVFUb1dYNU1nWnZlQT09>

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Or by telephone:

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If there is a problem getting through to that number, please call 603-542-7002.

Members of the Council present, including location and who was in the room:

Ward I Councilor Andrew O'Hearne – Council Chambers, Councilors Sweetser & Stone

At-Large Councilor Dale Girard – Home, alone

At-Large Councilor Erica Sweetser – Council Chambers, Councilors O'Hearne & Stone

Assistant Mayor Allen Damren – Home, alone

Mayor Charlene Lovett – Home, alone

At-Large Councilor Debora Matteau – Home, alone

At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski – Office, alone

Ward II Councilor James Contois – Home, alone

Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone – Council Chambers, Councilors O'Hearne & Sweetser

Also present:

Edward Morris, City Manager

Mary Walter, Finance Director

AGENDA CHANGES

Mayor Lovett requested to move Focus Areas to Support Priority Areas to the next meeting as she was not able to get the background information into the packet due to family issues.

REPORT OF THE SECRETARY

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Girard to accept the minutes of the February 24, 2021, City Council meeting, as amended.

Mayor Lovett said on page 11, “There was a discussion about the sidewalk material and that it should be a future agenda item.” should read, “There was a discussion about sidewalks and the need to update the City Code appendix pertaining to them and that it should be a future agenda item.”

Roll call vote:

O’Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - abstain

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 8-0, 1 abstain.

MAYOR’S NOTES

Mayor Lovett’s notes:

- Earth day is April 22. She thanked the community for the work that has been done in past years. If anyone wants to participate in the cleanup, they can reach out to the City Manager’s office.
- April 4th is Easter. She encouraged everyone to follow CDC guidelines.
- NH Food Bank food distribution will be mid-April at Runnings.

CITY MANAGER’S REPORT

- **Deputy Chief Mark Grasso Introduction** – Mr. Morris introduced Mark Grasso who is a retired Connecticut State Trooper and gave some of his background including that he has a Master’s Degree in Fire Science and a graduate certificate in public management and law enforcement leadership.
- **Airport COVID Reimbursement** – Fire Chief Burr has been advised of another operations reimbursement grant from NH Department of Transportation Bureau of Aeronautics. This will come to the City Council for acceptance.
- **Fire Department Grant Award** - The Fire Department has been awarded \$2,700.00 of the \$3,118.00 it will cost to purchase a Sparky the Fire Dog costume. This will be a

great addition to our fire prevention program and will be used during the annual fire prevention parade, and for many other events.

- **Earth Day-** The City of Claremont will be coordinating clean-up efforts across the City of Claremont during and around the week of Earth Day (April 22, 2021). A list of areas needing clean-up will be released in the near future. We encourage people to get out and help “Clean up Claremont”

The City will also be offering free tire disposal for residents on Saturday, April 24th, 2021 – 8:00 AM to 3:45 PM at the Transfer Station located at 875 Washington St. Claremont residents may drop off car and/or light truck tires (less than 20” – with or without rims). Businesses are not eligible to participate, and residents must have a Transfer Station decal.

- **Pleasant Street** - The City continues to work with our Engineers to finalize the plans for the Pleasant Street Project. We have recently met with the Pleasant Street building owners to discuss the plans and infrastructure options for water, wastewater, storm water, and fire protection during construction. We expect the RFP to go out sometime this week, with a late spring or early summer start date.
- **Continued Learning Partnership** - The Claremont School District and the Claremont Savings Bank Community Center are partnering to provide continued learning experiences for a six-week period this summer 8:30 am to 5:00 pm. Each day will start with a morning of academics followed by an afternoon of enriching experiences connected to weekly themes. Each week will also include a field trip experience. This exciting summer opportunity is for all students currently in kindergarten through fifth grade.
- **COVID-19 Update** – At the time this report was written, active COVID-19 cases throughout the State of New Hampshire, and here in Claremont, continue to decline. As of today, there were 9 active cases. Infection rate was .71, and as of today it is .81. Reminder to everyone to maintain vigilance.

Vaccinations:

Note: The Claremont fixed vaccination site is not closing and as of now, there are no plans to close. The State VINI program is working. Still on track to open vaccinations for all in May.

Mr. Morris said that Claremont has been chosen to be a part of the 10-week program, Everyone Eats. Restaurants provide meals to the Claremont Soup Kitchen and those restaurants are paid \$10 per meal.

Mr. Morris said that Finance Director Mary Walter has given notice that she is retiring mid-July. Staff is working on the recruitment package. This is a critical position. She will be greatly missed.

Regarding the Pleasant Street Project, Councilor Girard asked about the Truck Study from last year. Mr. Morris said the Truck Route will go up Union & Mulberry Street, headed south, and then from South Street, north on Broad Street.

Mr. Koloski asked if the money that was approved was expended. Mr. Morris believes it was part of the engineering costs.

CITIZEN'S FORUM

None.

OLD BUSINESS

Legislative Update

Mayor Lovett said in the Council packet there was a letter to the House Finance Committee regarding her concerns with their proposed budget which would continue the suspension of RSA 31-A Revenue Sharing; not the full distribution of the rooms & meals tax; and state aid grants (SAG). There is an amendment proposed to suspend all SAG contributions whether or not substantially completed. That is a cost of well over \$200,000 per year to Claremont. Because our revenue sharing was suspended, and we did not get our full distribution of rooms and meals tax (should have been 40%) over the last 10 years, Claremont has lost over \$10 million in revenue.

Focus Areas to Support Priority Areas

Moved to April 14.

City Fee Schedule – Public Hearing

A motion was made by Councilor O'Hearne and seconded by Councilor Stone to take City Fee Schedule off the table.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Mr. Morris said that Councilor questions and answers were included in the Council packet. There was a question about the differences in copy fees. Mr. Morris thinks we need to clarify that in the Fee Schedule. Assessing charges \$1 for Tax Report and that is because it is a double-side report. Assessing – Tax Maps are more expensive as they are color (black & white \$0.50, color \$1.00). He thinks these can be put on the All Departments page and delete the information from the other pages.

There was a discussion about removing Games of Chance/Raffles as they are only allowed for charitable organizations. Mr. Morris explained it is a benefit to leave this on so that when a permit is requested, the City can help organizations understand what the law allows them to do. Mr. Morris also recommended keeping Games of Chance/Raffles; and Live Entertainment in the Fee Schedule. There have been times when Live Entertainment events have happened. He said he would leave Carnival, Circus, Wild West Show, Small Tent Show up to the Council. Councilor Koloski was in favor of leaving it. Fire Chief Bryan Burr agreed with Councilor Koloski saying that a few times we have carnivals, it does trigger the need for safety inspections. It is a critical permit to make sure the operation is safe. Assistant Mayor Damren said he is in favor of leaving it as part of the Fee Schedule.

Regarding the increase for Monitoring of Private Fire Alarm Systems – Inside City Limits/Wired System, Chief Burr said the cost of operating the system is distributed to the users. Each year, when the billing goes out, users are informed of the impending increase. Users have been notified of increases since 2013.

Councilor Koloski said he had previously asked if when food service licenses are issued if the City ensures the restaurant has an active rooms & meals license from the State of NH. The answer was that the City doesn't do that. He had a conversation with the Department of Revenue Administration and they were surprised that the City doesn't look for that. If the City did that, it would assist in compliance and it may be a customer service issue to let businesses know they need that.

Changes/questions:

- Consistency of Copy Fees
- Consistency of Research Fees
- Voter Mailing Labels Each Ward Fee does not add up to Complete Set Fee
- Library – Non-Resident Fees 4-Month Card does not equal Full Year
- Add City Code reference in the Fee Schedule that covers fees

Mayor Lovett opened the public hearing. No one spoke. She closed it.

Mr. Morris said all the changes listed above can be done, but regarding Library – Non-Resident Fees 4-Month Card does not equal Full Year, that could be because the \$60 may be an incentive to have a card for a full year to save some money.

There was a brief discussion about approving the changes as discussed, and then bringing back the change to the Library at the next meeting.

A motion was made by Councilor O’Hearne and seconded by Councilor Stone to table this to the next meeting.

Roll call vote:

O’Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - no

Matteau - no

Koloski - yes

Contois - no

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 6-3.

Stevens Brook Conservation Easement Access Update

Nancy Merrill, Planning and Development Director, said that in July, Council approved the Conservation Commission having this access to this parcel in order to investigate access to the Stevens Brook Trail.

deForest Bearse, Resource Coordinator, shared a PowerPoint presentation.

- Stevens Brook Conservation Easement – Proposed North Street Access and Parking
- Easement Access
 - When this easement was created in 2011, no provisions were made for public access to it
 - There is no frontage on a public right-of-way
 - The Conservation Commission would like to create a walking trail through the 22 acres of the easement for public education and enjoyment
 - The Commission has engaged SnowHawk LLC to design and construct the trail
 - The Commission has been relying on the Tractor Supply store’s proximity to the easement to get to it
 - This arrangement is informal and entirely dependent upon the store manager
 - The Commission seeks a permanent, dedicated access so they can make it available to the public in the future
- Proposed Access
 - The Commission proposes to access the easement from North Street by the following:
 - Annex a 45-ft wide strip of land along the easterly boundary of parcel 83-2 (adjacent to the Todd Osgood easement) from parcel 95-27 to parcel 83-2. This would accommodate a small, 35-ft x 45-ft, 3-space parking area.

- The annexed portion would connect with a 15-ft wide path across the northerly boundary of parcel 83-2 to provide access onto the Stevens Brook easement. The 15-ft wide path would be reserved for use by the public when parcel 83-2 is sold.

She said the Commission seeks permission to continue to pursue this alternate path.

Ms. Merrill said the City-owned property with the house on it will go out to auction. The City is waiting for final design of the North & Main Street Project before moving forward. It is a large parcel, 3 ½ acres. What was shown tonight takes up ½ an acre, leaving approximately 3 acres. The easement has a deeded conservation over the Osgood property.

Gary Dickerman, Ward 1 resident and Chairman of the Conservation Commission. Thanked Ms. Merrill and Ms. Bearse for the work on this presentation. Boundaries are clearly marked and signage posted. The Commission would like to proceed with the plans for the trail, so they need this access.

Steve Wood, Conservation Commission member, said when you are in the middle of that conservation easement, you don't hear the traffic noise. The area offers a lot of opportunity for education. He would appreciate the Commission being able to complete this.

Jack Hurley, Ward 2, said this is a beautiful piece of land and the easement will make access possible.

Ms. Bearse said the hope is to put up signs to make people aware of the easement as well as directional signage. The 45-ft easement will allow people to drive in, park, and then drive out, instead of backing into traffic. It is unknown, at this time, what the road surface will be. The Commission is looking for consensus for the Commission to continue to work on this and come to the Council with motion(s) at a later time.

Mr. Dickerman said the area is on North Street, across from the cemetery, on the flat area of the road.

There was a consensus of the majority of the Council that the Conservation Commission and City Staff move forward with this.

Councilor O'Hearne was concerned about the potential liability to the City because it was stated it would be dangerous for vehicles to back onto North Street. When asked, Mr. Dickerman said for now, the area would be open in the summer, but it depends on Public Works plowing whether or not it would be open in the winter. Councilor O'Hearne was also concerned about the slippery hill in the winter. Ms. Merrill said this could have technical review to include Fire, Police, Public Works and Planning. Mr. Morris said this will be a collaborative effort and, if needed, could include NH DOT (Department of Transportation).

Councilor O'Hearne asked about the truck route. Mr. Morris said trucks will be routed down North Street.

Eileen Skowronski, Conservation Commission member, said she thinks signage could be set up warning about the traffic.

NEW BUSINESS

Sullivan County ATV Club Biennial Trail Permission

Steven Wilkie, Sullivan County ATV (SCATV) Club, said the biggest complaints have been on Cat Hole Road. Last year the Club did \$20,000 in Grant In Aid work. They will do more this year. One member did an anti-litter campaign all year and they will continue the anti-litter campaign this year. They are working alongside the snowmobile club to replace a bridge on Cornish Turnpike, over the Whitewater Reservoir Brook.

Michael Saracino, Cat Hole Road resident, said he has nothing against ATVs. However, he lives right near the road, on Cat Hole Road. He has a small front yard with large perennial gardens. On any given weekend there can be a few hundred ATVs that drive past his home and that kicks up a lot of dust. The ATVs drive through, even at night. If his family wants peace and quiet, they have to leave. When Police are around, people drive the speed limit, but not when they leave. SCATV Club members comply with the speed limit, but others do not. He would like to not have hundreds of ATVs go by his house.

Maggie Saracino, Cat Hole Road resident, said they can't leave windows open because of the dust.

Mr. Wilkie said ATVs have been allowed to use Cat Hole Road since 2013. By state law, machines are not allowed to operate 30 minutes after sunset, subject to a \$240 fine. He said Claremont Police gets grants from Fish & Game for enforcement. SCATV Club has been searching for other alternatives. They're asking to use Slab City Road, also, in order to get onto the snowmobile trails. Another option is if they can get a parking area on the Newport side of Cat Hole Road, and relieve a lot of pressure from Burger King. Parking at Burger King is burdensome to the Club, because they put out cones for traffic, etc. They need City permission for Slab City Road, in order to request permission from the landowners there.

Mr. Wilkie said the Club is actively working with landowners to relieve pressure on Cat Hole Road. If Cat Hole Road is removed, they would go from 50 parking spaces to 6. Trailers would go by the house instead of machines. He would rather keep it open and look for other options.

Mr. Morris said Cat Hole Road was taken from hard pack to dirt because the road was in such bad shape. Mr. Wilkie suggested the City may be able to apply for Grant-In-Aid in order to pave that portion of the road.

Regarding enforcement, Chief Chase said the grant received is limited. When Police are out there, there is great compliance. The Police Department doesn't get up there as much as residents would like to see.

Chief Chase said that ATVs are not allowed on the trails now. Mr. Wilkie said the official opening date is May 23. However, the Sugar River Trail near Home Depot is open all year.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor O'Hearne to table this.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - no

Sweetser - no

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - no

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 6-3.

Mayor Lovett said we could try to put this on the April 14 agenda, or if not, put on the April 28 agenda.

Donation of \$250 Tree for City Park

Mr. Morris said the Claremont Democrats are wanting to donate a tree to the City.

Mark Brislin, Parks and Recreation Director, said they are working with Lee Stevens, Log Cabin Nursery, to determine the proper tree and the location for the tree. The Claremont Democrats have agreed to take care of the tree until it is established.

Councilor Contois said if this is approved, the Claremont Democrats have put out a challenge to other civic organizations to make a similar long-term contributions to improving our City.

A motion was made by Assistant Mayor Damren and seconded by Councilor Matteau that the Claremont City Council hereby accepts with sincere appreciation the donation of a tree from the Claremont Democrats to be planted in a City Park, valued at approximately \$250.00.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

Donation of Electric Fireplace for Airport Terminal Building

Chief Burr said that Joe Osgood has donated an electric mantel-type fireplace to the Airport terminal building.

A motion was made by Councilor Girard and seconded by Assistant Mayor Damren that the Claremont City Council hereby accepts with sincere appreciation the donation of an electric fireplace from Joe Osgood to be placed at the Airport Terminal Building, valued at approximately \$80.00.

Roll call vote:
O'Hearne - yes
Girard - yes
Sweetser - yes
Damren - yes
Matteau - yes
Koloski - yes
Contois - yes
Stone - yes
Lovett - yes
Motion carried 9-0.

Water/Sewer Rates Presentation

Mr. Morris said last year, Council was given an overview of the water rates and where we were headed. This is a five-year rate structure proposal presentation. This will come back to the Council next month for a vote.

Alex Gleeson, Public Works Director, and Paul Cioffi showed a PowerPoint presentation: City of Claremont, NH Water and Sewer Rate Analysis & Recommendation

- History
 - In 2016 a rate study was done which revealed, at the time, that our rate structure did not align with our costs
 - Water rates for large water users increased an average of 17% annually; while the low consumer rate stayed the same. Sewer rates have remained unchanged over the last 5 years.
- Full-Cost Recovery (FY2022 Project Water & Sewer)
 - Operating expenses - \$3,084,730
 - Existing debt payments - \$1,287,533
 - Future depreciation - \$1,137,100

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- Total - \$5,509,363
- Encourage Development
- W&S Rates FY 2016-FY2021 (Per Quarterly Billing Period)

Water	# of Custs	FY2016	FY2017	FY2018	FY2019	FY2020	FY2021
Fixed Fee (5/8" meter)		\$ 9.50	\$ 11.15	\$ 13.10	\$ 15.40	\$ 18.10	\$ 18.10
0-1,000 Cu. Ft. Used	902	\$ 2.40	\$ 2.40	\$ 2.40	\$ 2.40	\$ 2.40	\$ 2.40
1,001-12,500 Cu. Ft. Used	2,149	\$ 4.10	\$ 4.80	\$ 5.60	\$ 6.60	\$ 7.80	\$ 7.80
12,501-50,000 Cu. Ft. Used	196	\$ 3.20	\$ 3.80	\$ 4.50	\$ 5.30	\$ 6.20	\$ 6.20
>50,000 Cu Ft Used	38	\$ 2.90	\$ 3.40	\$ 4.00	\$ 4.70	\$ 5.50	\$ 5.50

Sewer		FY2016	FY2017	FY2018	FY2019	FY2020	FY2021
Fixed Fee		\$ 49.00	\$ 49.00	\$ 49.00	\$ 49.00	\$ 49.00	\$ 49.00
All Usage		\$ 5.90	\$ 5.90	\$ 5.90	\$ 5.90	\$ 5.90	\$ 5.90

Usage rates are per 100 Cu. Ft.

- Claremont Sample Bills FY2016-FY2021 (Per Quarterly Billing Period)

Combined Water & Sewer Quarterly Bill									
	Meter Size	Usage (cf)	FY 2016	FY 2017	FY 2018	FY 2019	FY 2020	FY 2021	Avg Annual Increase
Minimal User (1 person HH)	5/8"	750	\$ 120.75	\$ 122.40	\$ 124.35	\$ 126.65	\$ 129.35	\$ 129.35	*1.4%
Avg Claremont User	5/8"	1,605	\$ 202.00	\$ 207.89	\$ 214.68	\$ 223.03	\$ 232.99	\$ 232.99	3.1%
Medium Commercial User	2"	12,000	\$1,307.90	\$1,398.20	\$1,501.80	\$1,630.20	\$1,783.80	\$1,783.80	7.3%
Large Commercial User	2"	18,000	\$1,858.40	\$1,985.20	\$2,131.30	\$2,308.70	\$2,539.80	\$2,539.80	7.1%

- Assumptions used to develop Claremont Proposed W&S Rates
 - Operating costs increase 2% per year
 - No customer growth
 - No change in consumption
 - No growth in miscellaneous revenue (interest, capacity, septage)
 - Rates are set to cover full cost
- Proposed Claremont Rate Structure

**PROPOSED CLAREMONT RATE STRUCTURE
PER QUARTERLY BILLING**

WATER	# of Cust	FY 2021	Proposed FY 2022	Proposed FY 2023	Proposed FY 2024	Proposed FY 2025	Proposed FY 2026
Fixed Fee (5/8" Meter)		\$ 18.10	\$ 18.60	\$ 19.10	\$ 19.60	\$ 20.15	\$ 20.70
0-1,000 CF Used	902	\$ 2.40	\$ 2.50	\$ 2.60	\$ 2.70	\$ 2.80	\$ 2.90
1,001-12,500 CF Used	2,149	\$ 7.80	\$ 7.20	\$ 7.40	\$ 7.60	\$ 7.80	\$ 8.00
12,501 - 50,000 CF Used	196	\$ 6.20					
Over 50,000 CF Used	38	\$ 5.50	\$ 5.70	\$ 5.90	\$ 6.10	\$ 6.30	\$ 6.50
Flat Water Rate	79	\$ 191.60	\$ 196.75	\$ 202.05	\$ 207.50	\$ 213.10	\$ 218.85

SEWER	# of Cust	FY 2021	Proposed FY 2022	Proposed FY 2023	Proposed FY 2024	Proposed FY 2025	Proposed FY 2026
Fixed Fee		\$ 49.00	\$ 50.25	\$ 51.55	\$ 52.90	\$ 54.30	\$ 55.70
All Usage	2,627	\$ 5.90	\$ 6.10	\$ 6.30	\$ 6.50	\$ 6.70	\$ 6.90
Flat Sewer Rate	11	\$ 179.50	\$ 184.15	\$ 188.95	\$ 193.85	\$ 198.90	\$ 204.05

- Usage rates are per 100 Cu Ft (CF)
- Proposed Claremont Sample Bills

Combined Water and Sewer Sample Quarterly Bills for Claremont													
		Meter Size	Usage (cf)	FY 2021	FY 2022	FY 2023	FY 2024	FY 2025	FY 2026	Avg Annual % Increase 2016->2021	Avg Annual % Increase 2021->2026	Avg Annual % Increase 2016->2026	
Minimal User (Avg 1 person HH)		5/8"	750	\$ 129.35	\$ 133.35	\$ 137.40	\$ 141.50	\$ 145.70	\$ 149.90	1.4%	3.2%	2.4%	
Avg Claremont Residential		5/8"	1,605	\$ 232.99	\$ 235.32	\$ 242.54	\$ 249.81	\$ 257.18	\$ 264.55	3.1%	2.7%	3.1%	
Medium Commercial User		2"	12,000	\$ 1,783.80	\$ 1,748.05	\$ 1,800.35	\$ 1,852.70	\$ 1,905.50	\$ 1,958.30	7.3%	2.0%	5.0%	
Large Commercial User		2"	18,000	\$ 2,517.80	\$ 2,546.05	\$ 2,622.35	\$ 2,698.70	\$ 2,775.50	\$ 2,852.30	7.1%	2.7%	5.3%	
Super Commercial User		2"	200,000	\$23,489.80	\$24,502.05	\$25,306.35	\$ 26,110.70	\$ 26,915.50	\$27,720.30	6.1%	3.6%	5.4%	
Avg Yrly increase FY2016 to FY2021 – 1 person HH					\$ 6.88		Avg Yrly increase FY2021 to FY2026 – 1 person HH					\$ 16.44	
Avg Yrly increase FY2016 to FY2021 - Avg Claremont User					\$ 25.99		Avg Yrly increase FY2021 to FY2026 – Avg Claremont User					\$ 25.25	
Avg Yrly increase FY2016 to FY2021 - Med Commercial User					\$380.84		Avg Yrly increase FY2021 to FY2026 – Med Commercial User					\$ 139.60	
Avg Yrly increase FY2016 to FY2021- Lrg Commercial User					\$527.64		Avg Yrly increase FY2021 to FY2026 – Lrg Commercial User					\$ 267.60	
Avg Yrly increase FY2016 to FY2021 – Super Comm User					\$4,415.64		Avg Yrly increase FY2021 to FY2026 - Super Comm User					\$3,384.40	

- Revenue vs Revenue Requirements – Water
- Revenue vs Revenue Requirements – Sewer
- FY2022 Monthly Water & Sewer Bill Comparison
- Maintain Adequate Cash Reserves
- AWWA Benchmarks for Cash Reserves
- Claremont Cash Balances vs AWWA Benchmarks

Cash Fund (W&S)	Bal @ 6/30/2020	Compared to AWWA Benchmarks
Operating-incl due from gen fund	4,580,243	12.5 months of operating expenses (Max)
Capacity Replacement	533,854	included in other reserves
Capital Reserve	131,356	included in other reserves
Stabilization & Contingency Reserve	1,071,164	21% of annual revenue (Good)
Emergency Plant Reserve	1,001,185	2% of fixed assets (Max)
System Replacement Reserve	2,188,803	10% of net fixed assets (High)

Overall Cash Reserves are adequate compared to AWWA benchmarks.

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- Moving Forward
 - Current rates expire June 30, 2021 and ideally the new rates would be adopted before that
 - The rate recommendation that is being proposed is meant to be fair and equitable for all members of the community, to promote future economic growth, and have the ability to maintain infrastructure stability for the City's water and sewer needs

Councilors asked clarifying questions and received answers. There was a question about drought and Mr. Morris said the City works with its Sourcewater Protection Plan and will monitor water levels.

There was a discussion about the 2% operating costs increase per year and that it is historically what forecast models have used. Mayor Lovett would be interested in getting the Claremont's exact percentage of cost increase.

Because of financial difficulties caused by COVID-19, a majority of the Council would like to see what it would look like if we froze the rate for 1 year and then do the 5-year increase in rates.

Mr. Morris said users use less than half the capacity of the water and sewer systems. There was a discussion about how to get more users onto the system.

If Councilors send Mr. Morris questions, he can answer them and then include them in the Council packet.

There was a discussion about properties being required to connect to the City's sewer system. Councilor Matteau will find and distribute the RSA that covers that.

Return to In-person Council Meetings Discussion

Mayor Lovett said that Vermont's target date is July 1, but that doesn't mean Council can't do something sooner.

Councilor Koloski had wanted to have this discussion. It's important to have remote access as well. It saves money by legal counsel not having to drive to be at the meetings.

Josh Nelson, CCTV (Claremont Community Television) Executive Director, said there have been sound updates in Council Chambers and things are working more smoothly. He is hopeful they will move forward with streaming next week.

Mayor Lovett reminded Councilors that the agreement was that all would wear masks when people were present in Council Chambers (one, or more, of the Councilors were not wearing masks).

Councilor Contois said it was important to note the Governor's Executive Orders regarding masks are still in effect until this Friday; allowing boards to meet by Zoom through March 26, 2021.

There was a discussion that the School Board is meeting in person as well as remotely. Councilors would like to keep the ability to meet remotely, in addition to meeting in person. They like that the meeting is streamed live on Facebook. Councilors were reminded that current law allows Councilors to participate in the meetings remotely, as long as there is a quorum of the Council present, in person.

Claremont Cultural Resources Discussion

A list of Claremont's cultural resources was distributed to the Council. It was noted the list was not complete. There are other items of cultural or historical significance throughout the community.

There was a discussion about creating an ad hoc committee; having a master list of all the items/structures (i.e. bowstring bridge) and where they are located. Also, there was a brief discussion about the building the Historical Society (HS) occupies and about the building reverting back to the City should the HS decide to relocate. Suggestion for discussion of the make-up of the ad hoc committee: five-person (1-public, 1-Councilor, City Manager, 1-Historic District Commission member, 1-Historical Society member). Mayor Lovett said the make-up of the ad hoc committee and its mission will be an agenda item on the April 28 agenda.

FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

Councilor Girard asked about the timeframe for the next audit. Ms. Walter said due to COVID, the audit was done offsite. She hopes to get a draft next week. After review, a final copy will be sent to Council. It's expected to be ready before the budget discussion.

Councilor Girard asked about lease payment schedule, start date, expiration date, and total cost.

Councilor Girard would like to have a discussion about trucks.

Councilor Girard asked about the \$1.28 million grant the City will be receiving. Mr. Morris said the City will get two payments, and is expecting to see \$640,000 in the next 90 days and then he will bring recommendations to the Council for ways to spend it. As more guidance is received, it will be forwarded to the Council. Some of those numbers will be used in the budget process.

Councilor Contois would like an update on the solar facility on Grissom lane.

Councilor Contois would like an update on the cell tower in the steeple of the Congregational Church.

Councilor Girard congratulated Ms. Walter on her upcoming retirement. He asked about the interim plan. Mr. Morris said that is an operational issue and that he has been in touch with MRI about hiring a contract Finance Director, if needed. He hopes to hire someone in time to overlap with Ms. Walter before she leaves. He has spoken to Ms. Walter about contracting her services to help the new person come up to speed. He'll have more details at the next Council meeting.

Mr. Morris listed the action items from tonight's meeting.

- Discussion with the Building Inspectors regarding the rooms & meal licenses and see if that is something that can be added to the checklist for the license
- Update the Fee Schedule; reference the ordinance in there; add to April 14 meeting, if possible; talk to the Library regarding fees
- Mr. Gleeson said, during the break, that upper Cat Hole Road is on this year's paving list
- Will look at the grant Mr. Wilkie talked about
- Add ATV Trail Permission to April 14 or 28 agenda and advise all participants
- Send Council copy of the Water & Sewer PowerPoint, and post it on the website
- Get more information on the charges on the water/sewer bills; calculate our costs over the last 5 years to see if they are in line with the 2% assumption that was used in making the rates
- Work with IT regarding Zoom & remote access as we return to in-person Council meetings

At 9:36 p.m., Councilor Koloski was having technical difficulties and he logged off.

- Keep watch on the Governor's Executive Orders regarding the ability to continue meeting via Zoom
- Look into the Historical Society deed and what the rules are
- Add historical resources to the April agenda
- Get together a long-term schedule for all leases for the budget discussion
- Will continue to research the Public Works vehicle color; discussion will be had with the Council before the purchase of the next vehicle
- Work on a solar facility update

- Work on cell tower in Congregational Church update
- Present long-term plan for the Finance Director

Mayor Lovett said at the next meeting, Councilors to discuss the budget schedule.

At 9:38 p.m. Councilor Koloski returned.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None.

ADJOURNMENT

At 9:39 p.m., a motion was made by Councilor Matteau and seconded by Councilor O'Hearne to adjourn.

Roll call vote:

O'Hearne - yes

Girard - yes

Sweetser - yes

Damren - yes

Matteau - yes

Koloski - yes

Contois - yes

Stone - yes

Lovett - yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council